

The Daylight between Adjectives and Adverbs

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Abstract Adjectives and adverbs are traditionally treated as two distinct categories, with adjectives modifying nouns (attributively or predicatively) and adverbs modifying verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs. However, a number of cases defy this binary classification: certain forms with adverbial morphology occur in predicative position, though they cannot be used attributively. Drawing on data from English, French, German, and Russian, we argue for a tripartite distinction between attributive adjectives, predicative adjectives, and adverbs. Russian provides the clearest instantiation of this system, with three distinct morphological forms. French and English show systematic syncretisms between the predicative and adverbial cells, while regular adjectives often syncretise the attributive and predicative cells. Adopting a Nanosyntactic framework, we propose that the distinction between attributive and predicative adjectives is encoded by a functional head JOIN (Fábregas 2024), which triggers additional agreement morphology. This analysis accounts for the distributional and morphological patterns across the three categories.

Keywords: adjectives, adverbs, predicative, attributive, agreement

1. Introduction

Adjectives and adverbs are parts of speech that are clearly related. Morphologically speaking, adverbs may be ostensibly derived from adjectives by adding a morpheme like *-ly* (1a). The adjective and the adverb may also be syncretic (1b), or the adverb may be suppletive with respect to the adjective (1c). There are also cases where an adverb lacks a corresponding adjective (1d).

(1)

	ADJECTIVE	ADVERB
a.	easy	easi-ly
b.	fast	fast
c.	good	well
d.		soon

Aside from their morphology, adjectives and adverbs also differ in their syntactic distribution. Thus adverbs modify verbs (2a), adjectives (2b), and other adverbs (2c).

- (2)
- a. She performed *terribly*.
 - b. *terribly* big
 - c. They drove *terribly* fast.

In contrast, adjectives modify nouns, whether they be used attributively (3a) or predicatively (3b).

- (3) a. a *terrible* performance
b. The performance was *terrible*.

In this paper, we investigate a number of cases where the morphology and the syntax do not line up in the way we would expect them to. This mismatch typically occurs in the predicative position illustrated in (3b), where adjectives are expected, but we can instead find forms that have the morphology of adverbs. These same forms cannot, however, occur as normal attributive adjectives. A case in point is the English suppletive adverb *well* (4a), which can occur predicatively (4b) but not attributively (4c).¹

- (4) a. They have performed well.
b. I'm not well.
c. *a well person

Although distributional oddities like these have been noted in the literature, grammars typically stick to the binary picture illustrated in (1), and represented schematically in (5), arguing that we are either dealing with an actual adverb or adjective (as the case may be), which has an uncharacteristic distribution.

(5)

	ADJECTIVE	ADVERB
a.	A	A-ly
b.	A	A
c.	A	B
d.		A

What we want to propose instead is that this binary picture is misguided, and that there is a category between adjectives and adverbs, which (for now) we shall call the 'predicative only' category.

(6)

	ADJECTIVE	PRED-ONLY	ADVERB
a.	A	A	A-ly
b.	A	A	A
c.	A	B	B
d.			A

As shown in the table in (7), in English regular adjectives like *easy*, we find a systematic syncretism between the regular adjective and the PRED-ONLY form, whereas in the *fast* class there is a syncretism that affects all three cells in the paradigm. The sup-

¹ Quirk et al. (1985:433) note that 'many people use such adjectives [i.e. ones that can be used only predicatively—AV & GVW] as attributives too, for example *A well person need see a doctor only for a periodic checkup*.' Although nothing much hinges on this for the present discussion, we ignore those speakers that accept *well* in attributive position.

pletive form *well* shows a syncretism between the PRED-ONLY form and the adverb. As we shall see, there also exist languages that have three distinct morphological forms, corresponding to the three categories that we propose in (6).

(7)

	ADJECTIVE	PRED-ONLY	ADVERB
a.	easy	easy	easi-ly
b.	fast	fast	fast
c.	good	well	well

The paper is structured as follows. In Sect. 2, 3, and 4 we present the empirical evidence from French, Russian, and German, respectively. Sect. 5 presents the prerequisites for the analysis, and Sect. 6 the necessary theoretical background from nanosyntax, which the analysis will rely on in Sect. 7, where we develop the analysis.

2. French

Regular French adverbs are derived by attaching the suffix *-ment* to the adjective (8a). Such adverbs have the semantics of a manner adverb: *facile-ment* ‘easily’ means ‘in an easy manner’. French also has three suppletive adverbs, which are listed in (8b).

(8)

	ADJECTIVE	ADVERB
a.	facile	facile-ment ‘easy’
b.	bon	bien ‘good’
	meilleur	mieux ‘better’
	mauvais	mal ‘bad’

These suppletive adverbs show the peculiar distributional property that they may occur in predicative position, as shown in (9) (examples from Abeillé & Godard 2021:902):

- (9)
- a. *La nouvelle proposition de Paul est très bien.*
the new proposal of Paul is very good.ADV
‘Paul’s new proposal is very good.’
 - b. *Ton livre est mieux que le mien.*
your book is better.ADV than the mine
‘Your book is better than mine.’
 - c. *Depuis qu’il a subi son opération, Paul est très mal.*
since that he has undergone his surgery Paul is very bad.ADV
‘Since he underwent surgery, Paul has been very bad.’

Yet they cannot appear in attributive position, where only the corresponding adjectives are possible:

- (10)
- a. *une bonne / *bien proposition*
a good.F.SG / good.ADV proposal
‘a good proposal’

- b. *un mauvais* / **mal* *livre*
 a bad.M.SG / bad.ADV book
 ‘a better book’

The prenominal position consistently accepts only true adjectives (subject to additional constraints, which we shall ignore here). In the postnominal position inside the noun, the picture is less clear, with some of the suppletive forms being able to occur post-nominally (11a), and others being impossible (11b). This suggests that postnominal adjectives are potentially predicates of reduced relatives (Cinque 2010).

- (11) a. *un homme bien*
 a man good.ADV
 ‘a decent guy’
 b. **un homme mal*
 a man bad.ADV
 Int. ‘a bad man’

The form *mal* ‘bad’ can also only be used predicatively to refer to a person’s health (as in (9c)), and not for example in (9a) (Abeillé & Godard 2021:902). These facts point to a semantic restriction in these PRED-ONLY forms, which makes their distribution accordingly restrictive (see also the discussion of (14) below).

Another context where regular adverbs are ruled out is the following:

- (12) *Je me sens libre* / **librement*.
 I me feel free / free.ADV
 ‘I feel free.’

This makes sense under an analysis where the adjective is an object complement, i.e. a predicate that is predicated of the object. The fact that suppletive adverbs can occur here is then in line with our earlier observation that they can occur in predicate position.

- (13) *Je me sens bien / mal / mieux*.
 I me feel well / bad / better
 ‘I feel well / bad / better.’

In a simple copular sentence, both the adjective and the suppletive adverb can occur, sometimes with a meaning difference, as illustrated in (14).

- (14) A: *Tu veux qu’ on s’occupe de Lucie demain?*
 you want that we REFL.occupy of Lucie tomorrow
 ‘Do you want us to take care of Lucie tomorrow?’
 B: *C’est bon / bien*.
 It is good / good.ADV
 ‘I agree.’ (*bon*)
 ‘It’s a good idea.’ (*bien*)

The traditional grammar view on these suppletive adverbs is that they fit into the binary adjective-adverb distinction, but behave uncharacteristically: ‘Some manner adverbs, degree adverbs and temporal adverbs can be predicates’ (Abeillé & Godard

2021:902—our translation). What we would like to suggest instead is that these cases provide evidence for a three-way distinction, in the manner outlined above:

(15)

ADJECTIVE	PRED-ONLY	ADVERB	
facile	facile	facile-ment	‘easy’
bon	bien	bien	‘good’
meilleur	mieux	mieux	‘better’
mauvais	mal	mal	‘bad’

As in English, regular adjectives show a syncretism between the adjective and the PRED ONLY form, whereas the suppletive adverbs are syncretic between the PRED ONLY category and the adverb.

Before moving on to the case of Russian, we note one further property of French adjectives, which will become relevant as we proceed. This property concerns the fact that adjectives show agreement with the noun they modify. The examples in (16) and (17) illustrate this for French attributive and predicative adjectives, respectively:

- (16) a. *un bon système*
a good.MASC system
‘a good system’
b. *une bonne solution*
a good.FEM solution
‘a good solution’
- (17) a. *Le système est bon.*
the solution is good.MASC
‘The system is good.’
b. *La solution est bonne.*
the solution is good.FEM
‘The solution is good.’

The marking of the agreement is identical in both cases. French has a two-gender system (MASC and FEM), and typically MASC gender is morphologically unmarked. Feminine gender is marked by the pronunciation of the final consonant of the root, which in the masculine is mostly unpronounced. This pattern can be accounted for by assuming that the feminine has an underlying representation (UR) with an unpronounced (floating) suffix /ə/, which protects the final consonant of the adjective from being unpronounced (see [Fathi & Lowenstamm 2016](#) for such an analysis of gender alternations in nouns; also [Cavirani 2022](#)). As a result, we get a surface representation (SR) where the final consonant of the root is pronounced. The table in (18) gives some relevant examples.

(18)

MASC		FEM		GLOSS
UR	SR	UR	SR	
bɔn	bõ	bɔn-ə	bɔn	‘good’
grand	grã	grand-ə	grãd	‘big’
pətit	pəti	pətit-ə	pətit	‘small’

These agreement data will become relevant as we dig deeper into the nature of the middle column of our paradigm.

3. Russian

Russian has a special interest in that it has three morphologically distinct forms for the three cells in the paradigm that we advocate. The difference concerns the agreement, in a manner that is distinct from the French pattern. Relevant forms are given in (19).

(19)

		ADJECTIVE	PRED-ONLY	ADVERB
NOM	MASC	krasiv-Ø-yj	krasiv-Ø	‘beautiful’
	FEM	krasiv-a-ja	krasiv-a	
	NEUT	krasiv-o-je	krasiv-o	krasiv-o
	PL	krasiv-y-je	krasiv-y	

In the traditional descriptions (e.g. [Wade 2011](#)) the names given to the first two columns of the paradigms in (19) are the ‘long form adjective’ (henceforth LF) and the ‘short form adjective’ (SF), respectively. The long form morphologically contains the short form, i.e. it is formed by adding an additional morpheme to the short form adjective. The adverb is syncretic with the neuter singular form of the SF adjective (as marked by the shading). The long forms are fully declinable, i.e. they have all the case forms beyond the nominative ones given in (19). In contrast, the short form adjectives only have the four nominative forms listed in (19).

Long form adjectives can be used both attributively (20a) and predicatively (20b).

- (20) a. *krasiv- a- ja devuška*
 beautiful AGR1 AGR2 girl.FEM
 ‘a beautiful girl’
 b. *Eta devuška krasiv- a- ja*
 this.FEM girl.FEM beautiful AGR1 AGR2
 ‘This girl is beautiful’

Short form adjectives are impossible in attributive position (21a), and only occur in predicative position (21b).

- (21) a. **krasiv- a devuška*
 beautiful AGR1 girl.FEM
 b. *Eta devuška krasiv- a*
 this.FEM girl.FEM beautiful AGR1
 ‘This girl is beautiful’

In sum, Russian has three morphologically distinct forms for the three cells in the paradigm. The (LF) adjectives are fully declinable, and can be used both predicatively and attributively. They morphologically contain SF (PRED-ONLY) adjectives. The latter can only occur predicatively, and only have nominative forms.

4. German

The agreement distinction between the Russian LF and SF adjectives is also found in German, albeit in a slightly different form. In German, attributive adjectives show agreement, whereas predicative ones do not (Vikner 2009; Fábregas 2024). This is shown schematically in (22) (where we only show the nominative forms of the attributive adjective, while noting that it is fully declinable for all case forms, like in Russian).

(22)

		ADJECTIVE	PRED-ONLY	ADVERB
NOM	MASC	schnell-er	schnell	schnell
	FEM	schnell-e	schnell	
	NEUT	schnell-es	schnell	
	PL	schnell-e	schnell	

Examples of attributively used inflected adjectives are given in (23), and of invariant predicative adjectives in (24).

- (23)
- a. *ein schnell-er Wagen*
a fast-NOM.M.SG car.M
'a fast car'
 - b. *eine schnell-e Handlung*
a fast-NOM.F.SG action.F
'a fast action'
 - c. *ein schnell-es Auto*
a fast-NOM.N.SG car.N
'a fast car'
 - d. *schnell-e Handlungen*
a fast-NOM.M.PL actions.F.PL
'fast actions'
- (24)
- a. *Der Wagen / Die Handlung / Das Auto ist schnell.*
the car.M / the action.F / the car.N is fast
'The car/The action/The car is fast.'
 - b. *Die Handlungen sind schnell.*
the actions.F.PL are fast
'The actions are fast.'

The distribution of the agreeing and the uninflected forms is straightforward: agreeing adjectives are attributive, and uninflected adjectives appear in the predicative position. In other words, German agreeing and invariant adjectives have the same distribution as the Russian LF and SF adjectives, respectively.

What is also comparable with the Russian situation is that the attributive adjective morphologically contains the predicative one, i.e. it consists of the predicative adjective followed by an extra agreement morpheme. The difference with Russian is that the predicative adjective is indeclinable and consists just of a single morpheme.

Vikner (2009) notes that the German pattern is also found in Dutch, West Flemish, Frisian, Swabian, Swiss German, and Yiddish. On the other hand, languages like French and the Scandinavian languages show no difference in terms of agreement between attributive and predicative adjectives.

5. Prerequisites for the analysis

In this section, we want to sharpen the labels for the three categories of our paradigm, in particular the middle category. It is tempting to conclude that the first two columns of our three-column paradigm are to be equated with the categories ‘attributive’ and ‘predicative,’ respectively. For German, such a relabelling of the columns is unproblematic, and provides a perfect fit with the data. On the other hand, for French and Russian, changing the column labels would complicate the distributional picture, as shown in (25):

(25)

	ATTRIBUTIVE	PREDICATIVE	ADVERB	
FRENCH	bon	bon bien	bien	‘good’
RUSSIAN	krasiv-a-ja	krasiv-a-ja krasiv-a	krasiv-o	‘beautiful’
GERMAN	schnell-e	schnell	schnell	‘fast’

Under this view, the predicative position can host both the adjective *bon* and the predicative adjective/adverb *bien* in French, and in Russian it can host both LF and SF adjectives.

However, for Russian at least, this picture can be improved upon. Matushansky (2008) (following Babby 1973; 1975; Siegel 1976; Bailyn 1994) argues that LF adjectives in Russian are always attributive, in the sense that they are followed by an empty noun when they appear in predicative position:

- (26) *Eta devuška krasiv- a- ja Ø_N*
 this.FEM girl.FEM beautiful AGR1 AGR2
 ‘This girl is beautiful.’ (Lit. ‘This girl is a beautiful one’)

If correct, we can improve the Russian part of the table in (25) as follows:

(27)

	ATTRIBUTIVE	PREDICATIVE	ADVERB	
RUSSIAN	krasiv-a-ja	krasiv-a	krasiv-o	‘beautiful’

That is, LF adjectives are always attributive, even when they appear not to be at first sight.²

Although we shall not go through all of Matushansky's arguments, there are just two that we shall mention. The first is that N-ellipsis is generally possible with attributive adjectives, as in the examples in (28) (from [Matushansky 2008:42](#)):

- (28) *Daj mne krasnuju / elektricheskiju / francuzskuju* $\emptyset_N$.
 give me red / electric / French
 'Give me the red/electric/French one.'

A second argument concerns a difference in interpretation between the short and the long form when they occur predicatively. [Milsark \(1977\)](#); [Carlson \(1977\)](#) point out that adjectival predicates may denote states (29a) or properties (29b), but that nominal predicates always denote properties (individual-level predicates, in Carlson's terms) (29c).

- (29) a. The man is drunk.
 b. The man is intelligent.
 c. The man is a drunk.

If indeed LF adjectives that occur predicatively have the structure in (26), we predict that they will denote properties, as opposed to SF adjectives. This prediction is indeed borne out, as shown by the minimal pair in (30) (A. Sergienko, p.c.) (see also [Matushansky 2008:47](#)).

- (30) a. *Ja bolen*.
 I ill.SF
 'I am ill.' (temporarily: state)
 b. *Ja bolnoj*.
 I ill.LF
 'I am ill'. (permanently, chronically: property)

Having thus identified the three categories of our paradigm as ATTRIBUTIVE, PREDICATIVE, and ADVERB, we can turn to the what is the basis of the attributive-predicative distinction. Before addressing that issue, we first present some basic assumptions of nanosyntax.

6. Nanosyntax

In Nanosyntax, every syntactic head is a feature, i.e. syntactic heads are atoms and do not have internal structure. Features are merged one by one, in an order determined by the functional sequence (*fseq*). At each Merge step, lexicalisation must first succeed before the next feature can be merged. To this end, the structure created by Merge is matched against the existing lexical entries of the particular language. This matching process is subject to the condition in (31):

² This leaves French as the only language type where the predicative column can be filled by two forms. We return to this state of affairs in Sect. 7.3 below.

(31) Condition on matching (De Clercq et al. 2025)

A lexically stored constituent L matches a syntactic phrase S iff S is identical to L.

When a matching item is found for the newly formed structure, the derivation may continue with the next Merge cycle. However, when no matching item is found, syntax tries to rescue the phrase marker by performing evacuation movements, and making a new attempt at lexicalisation by finding a match in the lexicon. The process is regulated by the Lexicalisation Algorithm in (32).³

(32) Lexicalisation Algorithm (based on De Clercq et al. 2025)

- a. Merge F and lexicalise FP
- b. If (a) fails, move the closest labelled node containing the bottom of the *fseq*
- c. If (b) fails, move the immediately dominating constituent and lexicalise (recursive)

Since features are atoms, morphemes lexicalising these features typically correspond to complex constituents, i.e. a single morpheme typically pronounces a whole constituent containing more than one syntactic head.

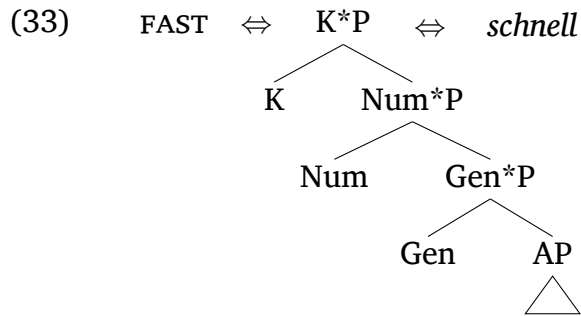
7. Analysis

7.1 German

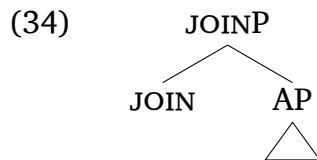
The analysis we shall develop is based on the proposal by Fábregas (2024) to account for the difference between German attributive and predicative adjectives. He argues that attributive adjectives differ from predicative ones in that they have a feature JOIN, which functions as a type-shifter, turning a predicate (type $\langle e, t \rangle$) into a modifier (type $\langle \langle e, t \rangle, \langle e, t \rangle \rangle$). He assigns to the German predicative adjective *schnell* ‘fast’ the lexical entry in (33) (where Gen*P, Num*P, and K*P each stand for a complex of heads relating to gender, number, and case, respectively).⁴

³ The LA also has a backtracking step, and a last resort option of starting a new derivation in a separate workspace, but since we shall not need those we ignore them for the purposes of the present discussion.

⁴ Fábregas has an additional MATCH head above KP, that instructs LF to check the two sets of features for compatibility, i.e. it triggers an agreement or concord operation between the adjective and the noun. We do not adopt this head, but instead follow Caha (2023) in assuming that agreement features introduce presuppositions on the modified noun (see also Sudo & Spathas 2020). The need to maximize such presuppositions both in the projection line of the noun and the adjective leads to the outcome that the features added to the adjective are exactly the same as those added to the noun. In this type of approach, there is no formal agreement operation, nor a feature MATCH triggering it. Fábregas’ lexical entry in (33) also ignores the syncretism between the predicative adjective and the adverb, for which we assume an ADV head on top of the adjective (see Sect. 7.2 below for discussion).



The fact that the root lexicalises the gender, number, and Case projections derives the property that we observed above that predicative adjectives are indeclinable.⁵ In the case of attributive adjectives, Fábregas argues that the JOIN head is merged directly on top of the AP.

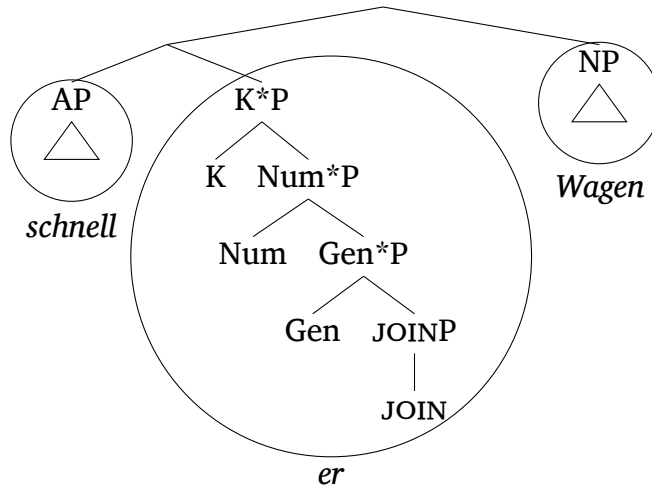


This structure cannot be lexicalised by the root, since it is not contained in its lexical entry (33). Evacuation movement will therefore be triggered, and a separate morpheme will lexicalise the number, gender, and Case features. Skipping several intermediate steps, the final representation that Fábregas assigns to *schnell-er Wagen* ‘fast car’ is shown in (35).⁶

⁵ A problem raised by this analysis is how the root can lexicalise different genders and numbers, as that would presuppose structural differences somewhere in the middle of the tree. One potential approach to this problem lets the lexical tree ‘shrink’ in the middle through the use of pointers (Caha & Pantcheva 2012; Vanden Wyngaerd 2018; Taraldsen 2019). An alternative view, suggested in Caha (2023), is that the agreement projections can be truncated from the top down, resulting in their complete absence and the consequent absence of agreement, or their partial absence and the presence of partial agreement. Under Caha’s view, the German predicative adjectives would lack the agreement projections, contrary to the view taken by Fábregas as represented in (33). A third possibility, which is suggested by our analysis of the adverbs in Sect. 7.2 below, is that the root lexicalises underspecified gender, number, and case, which makes it compatible with any noun.

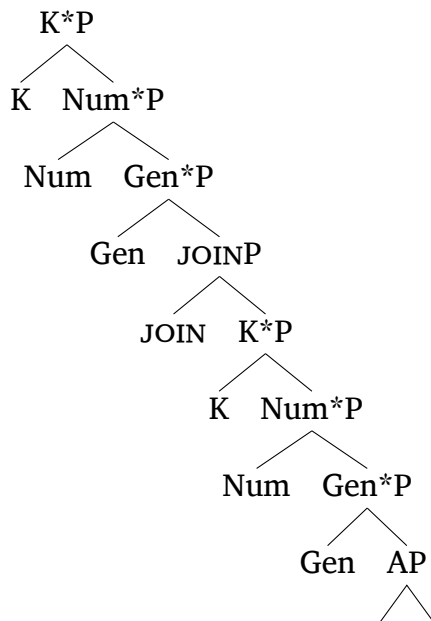
⁶ For the purposes of this paper we ignore the internal structure of the NP, which is also endowed with gender, number, and case features, which those of the adjective must match (see note 4).

(35)



However, the Russian data, and the LF adjectives in particular, suggest that the gender, number, and Case projections can occur twice (since there are two agreement morphemes). This observation can be accommodated by making a small modification to Fábregas' proposal, to the effect that the agreement projections can not only occur above the JOIN head, but also below it. The maximal functional sequence of the agreement projections above adjective then looks as in (36):

(36)



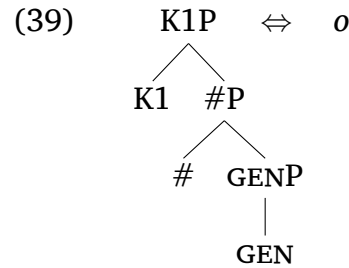
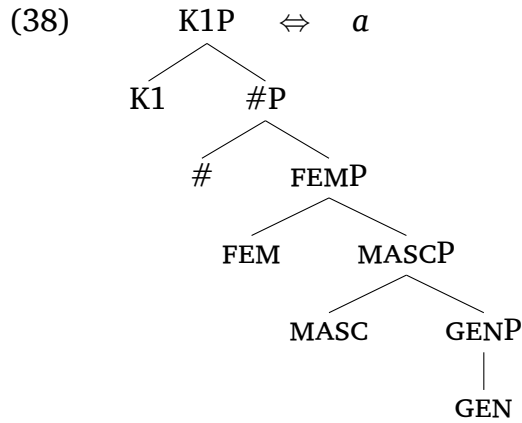
This minimal change to Fábregas' proposal will allow us to derive the distinction between SF and LF adjectives in Russian, as we shall proceed to show in the next section.

7.2 Russian

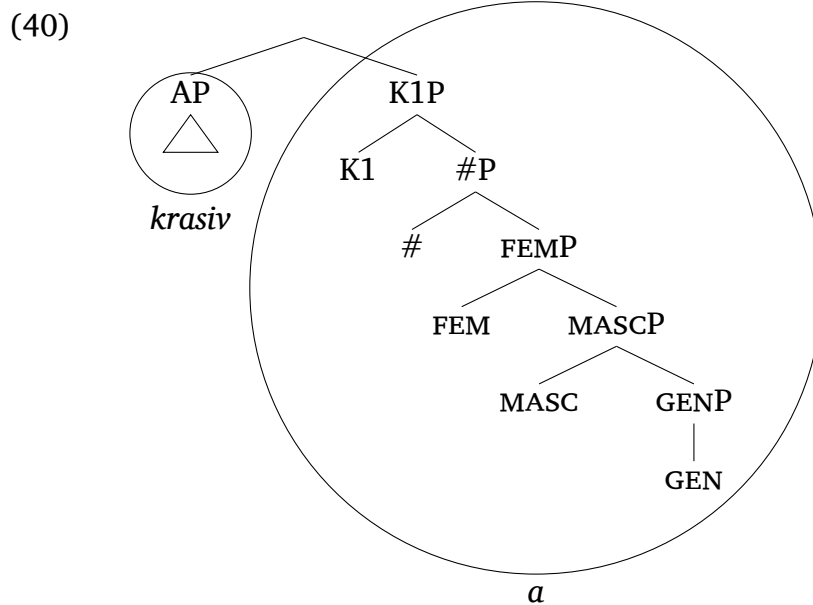
We shall assume that Russian adjectives are typically smaller than in German, as shown in the following lexical entry for the root *krasiv* ‘beautiful’, as well as the feminine and the neuter agreement endings for the SF in (38) and (39), respectively:⁷

(37) BEAUTIFUL $\Leftrightarrow$ AP $\Leftrightarrow$ *krasiv*





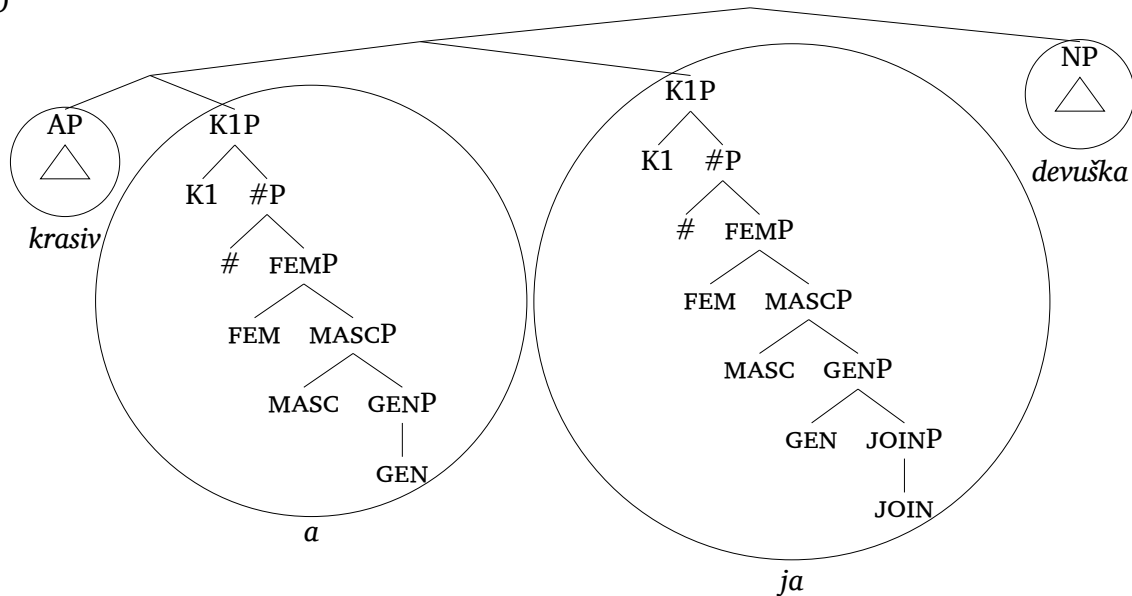
The predicative or SF adjective has the ϕ projections merged directly above the root, but since the root cannot lexicalise them (witness (37)), evacuation movement will be triggered, and a suffix will lexicalise the ϕ projections, as shown in (40) for the NOM.F.SG form, with the suffix *-a*.



⁷ We assume that feminine gender (FEM) contains masculine (MASC), which in turn contains the neuter (which we represent as by the default feature GEN for gender). We set aside here the masculine, where the SF adjective is suffixless. We assume that the root lexicalises the masculine gender feature, but the technical implementation of this idea requires a lexical entry with a Complex Left Branch (Blix 2022; De Clercq et al. 2025). For reasons of space, we cannot discuss this solution here.

Deriving the attributive adjective involves the merger of JOIN on top of this structure. Since the result of that merge cannot be lexicalised directly, (pied-piping) movement is triggered. This movement raises the SF adjective to the left, across the JOIN head, allowing JOIN to be lexicalised by the LF ending. Again skipping various intermediate steps, (41) shows the final representation for *krasivaja devuška* ‘beautiful girl’.

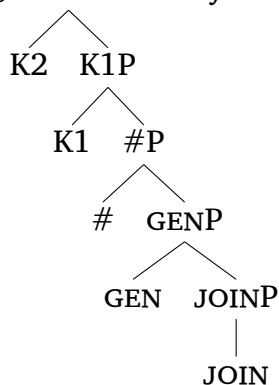
(41)



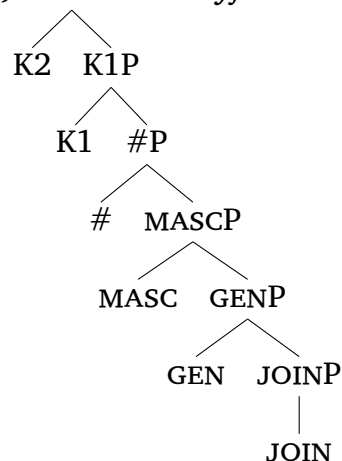
This approach explains why the LF adjectives have two agreement suffixes (at least in the feminine and the neuter), why the SF and the LF suffixes are different, and why the SF is restricted to the nominative forms. Starting with the first of these properties, the tree in (41) shows the two agreement suffixes graphically. Since the SF agreement suffix (-a) has no JOIN feature in its lexical entry, it cannot lexicalise it, and the LF suffix is called upon.

The analysis also explains why the agreement markers in the LF adjectives are different from the corresponding ones in the SF. The LF is derived by adding three distinct suffixes, -je, -yj, and -ja, for the NEUT, MASC, and FEM, respectively. Their lexical entries are shown below:

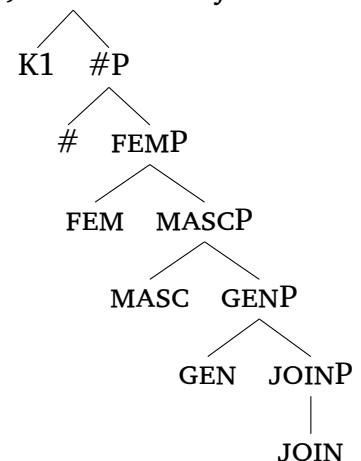
(42) K2P $\Leftrightarrow$ je



(43) K2P $\Leftrightarrow$ yj



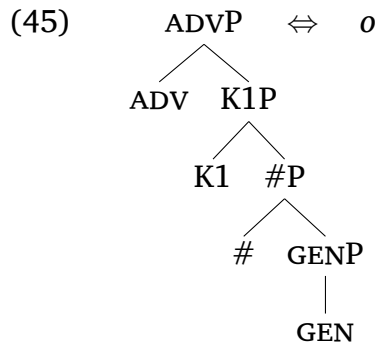
(44) K1P $\Leftrightarrow$ ja



The fact that these lexical entries all have the feature JOIN as their lowest feature makes them structurally different from the lexical entries for the agreement markers that we find in the SF adjective (compare the lexical entries for *-a* and *-o* in (38) and (39) above, respectively). As a result, we also predict their phonologies to be different, as they in fact are.

Finally, we explain why the SF adjectives are restricted to the nominative. The lexical entries for the (suffixes of the) SF adjectives in (38) and (39) all have K1 as their highest feature. This will prevent them from occurring in any other case than the nominative. In contrast, the LF endings of the neuter and the masculine are syncretic between NOM and ACC. This motivates lexical entries with K2 as the highest feature (see (42) and (43)). Other LF endings exist for the other case forms, but not for the SF.

To conclude this section on Russian, we want to discuss the case of the adverb, which is marked by the *-o* suffix, which is syncretic with the neuter agreement ending of the SF adjective. We want to maintain that the adverb contains an underspecified nominal/adjectival base. This base consists of the unmarked or default features GEN, #, and K1.⁸ On top of that sits an adverbial head. This means we update the lexical entry for *-o* as in (45) (compare with (39) above):

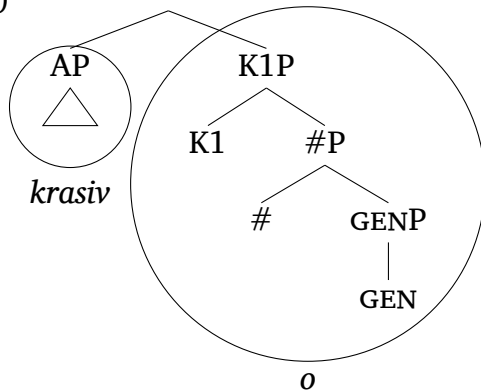


This suffix can now mark neuter gender in the SF adjective, as in (46), but also the adverb, as in (47). This is because the Matching Condition lets both of the syntactic constituents on the right of these trees find a match in the lexical entry in (45).⁹

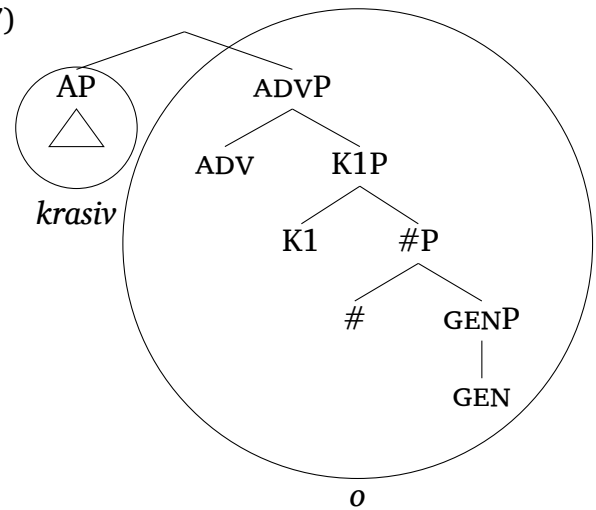
⁸ In a similar vein, Kayne (2005:177) suggests that in English, the adverbial suffix *-ly* is an affixal noun (see also Katz & Postal 1964:105, Emonds 1976:157, Alexeyenko (2015)).

⁹ This means that the attributive adjective and the adverb share a common base, the predicative adjective, to which they each add additional layers of structure. This is potentially problematic for a syncretism across the three cells of our paradigm, as with the English adverb/adjective *fast* (see (1) above). One way of approaching this issue is to assume that languages with adjectives that show no agreement lack the agreement projections, as suggested by Caha (2023) (see note 5 above).

(46)



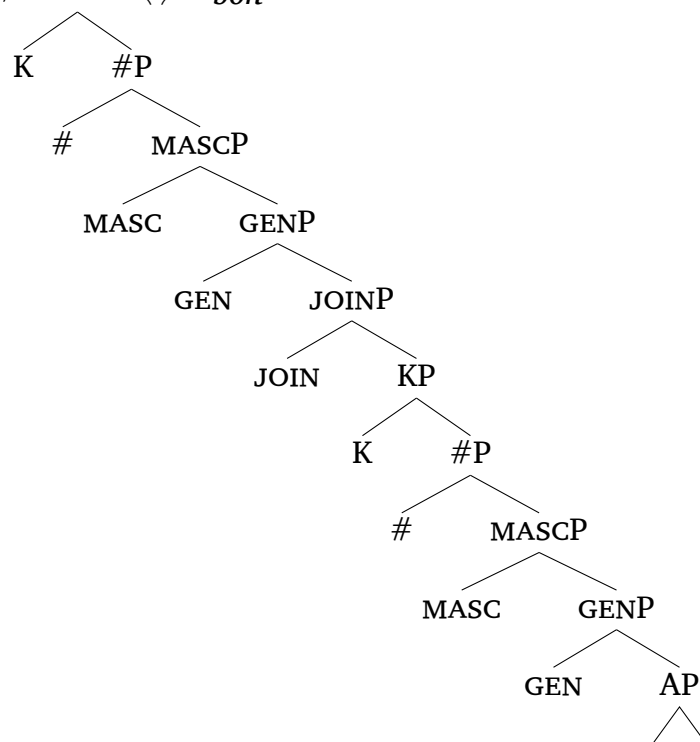
(47)



7.3 French

As we observed above, French attributive and predicative adjectives show the same agreement. Given that the masculine is morphologically unmarked, we assume that the root can lexicalise the MASC gender feature, as shown in the example lexical entry for the French adjective *bon* 'good' in (48):

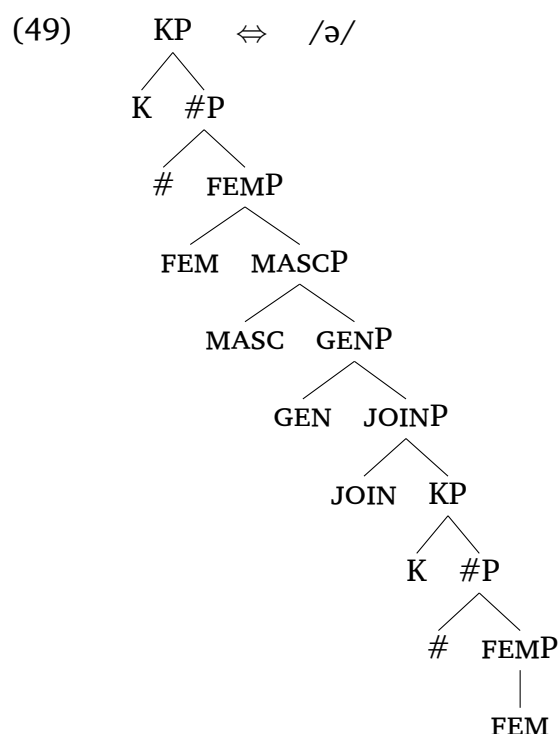
(48) GOOD $\Leftrightarrow$ KP $\Leftrightarrow$ *bon*



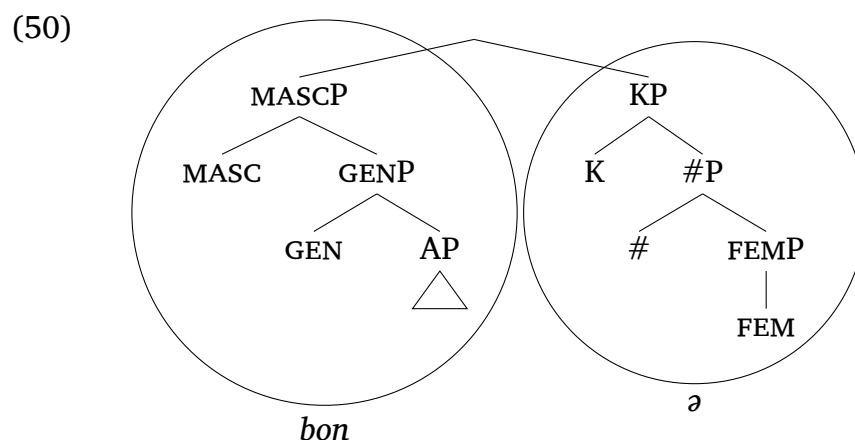
When the syntax builds a (masculine) predicative adjective, it finds a match in the lower KP of the lexical entry. An attributive adjective will find a match in the highest

KP. This derives the fact that the predicative and attributive adjective are syncretic (at least as far as the masculine is concerned).

In the feminine, the root cannot lexicalise the FEM feature, and so the /ə/ suffix appears. Its lexical entry is given in (49).



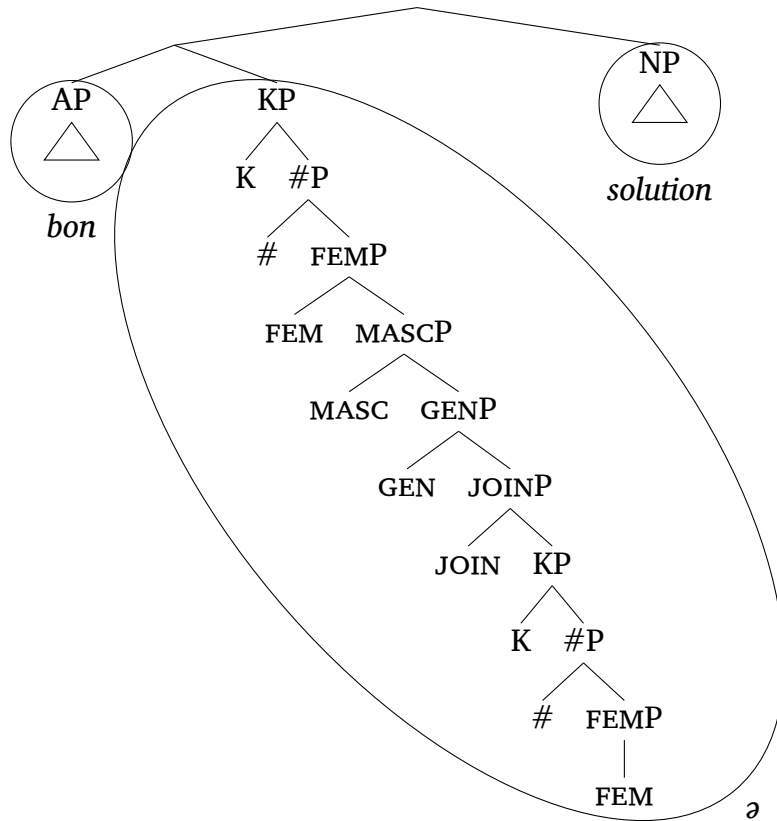
The predicative adjective has a structure which is reminiscent of that of the Russian SF adjective. The root can lexicalise the agreement projections up to MASCP, but then when FEM is merged, evacuation movement applies and the feature is lexicalised by the suffix. The final stage in the derivation of the feminine predicative adjective is shown in (50).



Different from Russian, the marking of the attributive adjective is identical to that of the predicative one. This is achieved by assigning to the suffix a lexical entry that can realise all the functional heads that sit above the root, as we have done in (49). The

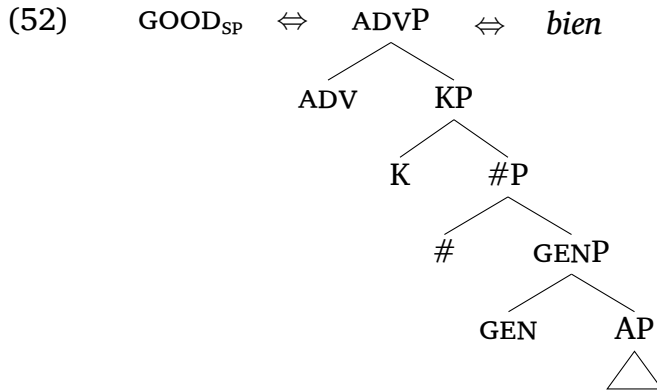
suffix will then be able to grow as JOIN and the heads above it are merged. In (51) we show the representation for *bonne solution* ‘good solution’.

(51)



This type of approach explains why there is only one agreement morpheme with attributive adjectives, and why the agreement marking is identical in the attributive and the predicative case.

A question to address for French specifically is how the derive the suppletive forms, which show a syncretism between the predicative adjective and the adverb. The approach is similar to Russian, which shows the same syncretism (for the neuter form of the adjective), albeit without suppletion. Besides being suppletive, the French form is also monomorphemic, i.e. its lexical entry can lexicalise the entire structure, so that no suffix is needed:



The matching condition makes this lexical entry a suitable candidate for both the adverb (ADVP) and the predicative adjective (KP), but not the attributive one, since it lacks the JOIN head. The subscript SP in the lexical entry stands for ‘specialised meaning’. This reflects the fact that the predicative *bien* is associated with a different concept than the (agreeing) adjective *bon* ‘good’, which can also appear in the predicative position, but is not semantically restricted in the way that *bien* is (see the discussion in Sect. 2 above).

8. Conclusion

In this paper, we have challenged the traditional binary view of adjectives and adverbs, arguing instead for a tripartite distinction between attributive adjectives, predicative adjectives, and adverbs. This proposal is grounded in morphological and syntactic evidence from English, French, German, and Russian, which reveals systematic patterns of syncretism and distributional restrictions that a simple binary model cannot adequately capture.

Building on insights from Nanosyntax, we developed a formal analysis in which these patterns emerge from the interaction between the functional sequence above the adjective and the lexicalisation algorithm. Key to our account is the distinction between attributive and predicative adjectives, which we attribute to the presence or absence of a functional head JOIN (Fábregas 2024). In languages like German and Russian, the presence of JOIN triggers additional agreement morphology in attributive positions, while in languages like French, the same morphology is used across both positions. The Russian data, with its double agreement marking on long form adjectives, further supports the idea that agreement projections can occur both below and above JOIN.

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